



FROM ZERO TO PRO - MODULE 08

Proteins II: Fish & Seafood

Seafood is delicate, fast, and unforgiving of overcooking; learn to buy, store, and cook it with confidence.

Week 14 - watch, study, cook, reflect

By the end of this module

- 1 Judge freshness and store seafood correctly.
- 2 Pan-sear fish for crisp skin; poach and steam delicate fillets.
- 3 Cook shellfish (shrimp, mussels, scallops) to just-done.
- 4 Portion a fillet and remove pin bones.

LESSON 8.1

Buying and Storing Seafood

Objective: Choose fresh seafood and store it correctly.

Key points

- Fresh fish smells briny and clean, never sour; flesh is firm and springy.
- Frozen-at-sea fish can beat tired 'fresh' fish at the counter.
- Store cold, dry, and well-wrapped; cook within a day or two.
- Buy when it is freshest and plan the meal around it.

Watch out for

- Buying fish that smells strongly fishy or looks dull and gaping.
- Letting seafood sit warm or swim in its own liquid.
- Holding fresh fish for days before cooking it.

LESSON 8.2

Pan-Searing Fish for Crisp Skin

Objective: Get crisp skin and a moist interior on a fillet.

Key points

- Dry skin + preheated pan + a brief press = crisp, flat skin.
- Cook mostly on the skin side; flip only to finish.
- Pull fish a little early - it cooks on off heat.
- Done = opaque and just-firm, flaking but still juicy.

Technique

- 1 Dry and season**
Pat the fillet bone-dry; salt the skin.
- 2 Lay skin-down**
Place into a hot, oiled pan, skin-side down.
- 3 Press**
Press gently for a few seconds so the skin stays flat.
- 4 Flip late**
Cook through on the skin, then flip briefly to finish.

LESSON 8.3

Poaching and Steaming

Objective: Cook delicate fish gently in liquid or vapor.

Key points

- Poach in barely-simmering liquid; never let it boil hard.
- Court bouillon (aromatic poaching liquid) adds flavor and becomes a sauce.
- Steaming preserves texture and takes well to aromatics.
- Stop as soon as the flesh turns opaque.

Watch out for

- Boiling the poaching liquid, which toughens and shreds the fish.
- Over-steaming until the fish is dry.
- Crowding the steamer so it cooks unevenly.

LESSON 8.4

Shellfish

Objective: Cook shrimp, mussels, and scallops to just-done.

Key points

- Shrimp: a loose C and opaque flesh is done; a tight O is overcooked.
- Mussels/clams steam open in minutes; discard any that stay shut.
- Use the broth shellfish release as an instant sauce.
- Scallops: bone-dry, hot pan, hard sear, barely-warm center.

Technique

- 1 Dry**
Pat shellfish very dry for searing; rinse and debeard mussels.
- 2 High heat**
Use a hot pan for scallops; a covered pot for mussels.
- 3 Watch closely**
Pull shrimp/scallops at just-done; mussels when open.
- 4 Sauce it**
Build a quick pan broth from the released liquid.

Practice & homework

1

Pan-sear a skin-on fillet to crisp skin without tearing.

2

Steam mussels and build a quick pan broth to serve with bread.

3

Cook scallops with a proper sear and a barely-warm center.

Watch & learn (free)



America's Test Kitchen (tested technique)

<https://www.youtube.com/@AmericasTestKitchen>



Ethan Chlebowski (the 'why' behind cooking)

<https://www.youtube.com/@EthanChlebowski>



ChefSteps (modern technique & sous vide)

<https://www.youtube.com/channel/UCxD2E-bVoUbaVFL0Q3PvJTg>



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Next up - Module 09: Baking & Pastry Fundamentals

FROM ZERO TO PRO - THE SELF-TAUGHT CHEF PROGRAM